



Return to form: Verstappen stormed to his second win this season — a crucial fightback after a rocky start to 2025. AFP

though it comes with its risks. But to Verstappen, any opportunity to pounce on the leader was welcome.

In a move that will be replayed for years, he braked late, swept around the outside of Piastri, and seized the lead with precision. It was daring yet calculated, and pure Verstappen — an overtake of the highest order.

Piastri likely expected pressure, but not such a bold lunge that early. Caught off guard, the Australian had no choice but to yield. While he stuck close in the following laps, the leader never put a wheel wrong thereafter and commanded the race in a vastly improved Red Bull.

Verstappen was further aided by pit stop strategies. What was expected to be a routine one-stop became anything but, thanks to the appearance of the Virtual Safety Car (VSC) and later, a full Safety Car (SC).

The slowed-down periods reshaped the race, especially for McLaren and a resurging Ferrari. When the VSC was triggered by Esteban Ocon parking trackside, Red Bull immediately pitted Verstappen, gaining an edge.

While Piastri opted for the otherwise advantageous undercut, the VSC came right after, forcing him to charge through the backmarkers

and lose out. Ferrari, which seemed to have found some rhythm to enter the top 10, saw Leclerc's momentum also take a hit.

Both drivers made their way quickly, but had to slam the brakes again when Kimi Antonelli's race came to a heartbreaking end. The SC was deployed, and it was another cheap stop to change tyres. But it was their teammates — Norris and Lewis Hamilton — who swapped to fresher rubber with a handful of laps remaining.

At the restart, Piastri and Leclerc were left fending for their positions rather than attacking for more points, eventually losing out to their partners. **Norris finished as the leading McLaren in second with Piastri in third. Fourth-placed Hamilton benefitted from the scuffle between Albon, who secured a second consecutive fifth-place finish, and Leclerc, who came sixth.**

Away from all the chaos, Verstappen stormed to the chequered flag for his second win this season — a crucial fightback after a rocky start to 2025. It also commemorated Red Bull's 400th Grand Prix start, a landmark achievement on a track where it has seen success thanks to its trailblazer.



MOTOGP



From an unbeaten sprint winner to a French hero after decades, the French Grand Prix witnessed MotoGP history.

Heading into the weekend with a one-point deficit to his younger brother, Marc Marquez (**in red**) was dealt a blow when home rider Fabio Quartararo secured his second successive pole by smashing the Le Mans lap record and starting ahead for both events.

The 26-year-old former world champion had crashed out at the last sprint, handing the place over to Marquez. This time, the Frenchman could not compete with the sheer pace of the Ducati, having to watch the Spaniard make it a sixth sprint win in a row, maintaining a perfect record. The main race, however, saw fortunes favour another hometown talent — Johann Zarco (**front**). The LCR Honda rider became the first Frenchman in 71 years to win the French Grand Prix. Zarco won by a huge margin of nearly 20 seconds ahead of Ducati's Marquez, who hasn't won a Sunday race in the last two events. But the latter still enjoys a 22-point lead atop the standings as the riding contingent travels to the Silverstone Circuit for the British Grand Prix.